

Demystifying the Mobile Backend-as-a-Service

Mobile and Web app developers now have reason to cheer, with the evolution of the Mobile Backend-as-a-Service (MBaaS) model. This article takes you through its intricacies.



Abbreviations like IaaS (Infrastructure-as-a-Service), PaaS (Platform-as-a-Service) and SaaS (Software-as-a-Service) come to the fore in discussions of cloud service models. These abbreviations are familiar to those who know of cloud technology models. Briefly, in the case of IaaS, the service provider gives just the infrastructure. With PaaS, the service provider gives a platform configured over the infrastructure. Finally, in the case of SaaS, the service provider gives the entire software over a configured platform on the infrastructure. This whole concept has been illustrated in Figure 1, made by the CIO Research Centre. The role played by the service provider increases from IaaS to PaaS to SaaS, while for users, it decreases. It is also apparent from this diagram that the customisation of the model and the technical knowhow of the developer are directly proportional to the 'You Manage' part in

the figure. The larger the 'You Manage' part is, the higher the level of customisation that can be achieved and the greater the amount of technical knowhow that developers must have.

The evolution of mobile technology, and the decrease in time-to-market for Web and mobile applications led to a new cloud service model in the form of the Backend-as-a-Service (BaaS), more commonly called Mobile Backend-as-a-Service (MBaaS). Wikipedia defines MBaaS as, "Backend as a service (BaaS), also known as 'mobile backend as a service' (MBaaS), is a model for providing Web and mobile app developers with a way to link their applications to backend cloud storage while also providing features such as user management, *push notifications*, and integration with *social networking services*." The need to accelerate mobile and Web app development is the reason for the birth and evolution of